

The Gujjar community is protesting the depiction of Prithviraj Chauhan as a Rajput icon. His father was called Gurjaradhipati. If the father was Gurjar, wouldn't the son be Gurjar too, they ask

the Sun. However, the family tree drawn in the early 12th century inscriptions at Sewari mention no link between Chauhans and the Sooryavansh; rather they are shown to be the children of Indra.

A third view portrays the Chamhanas as Brahmins. Veteran historian Dr Dashrath Sharma in his seminal 1959 book, *The Early Chauhan Dynasties*, refers to the 1170 CE Bijolia inscription of 'Chahmano', which talks of 'Vipra Shreevatsagotrebhuta', suggesting a Brahmin origin. A branch of the Chauhans, the Kayamkhani, are said to be Islamic converts. The late 17th century text *Kayam Khan Raso* by Niamat Khan Kayamkhani, also talks of Chauhans as Brahmins. But there is little else to substantiate the claim.

The origin story of the Chauhans takes an altogether different turn in Col. Tod's *Annals and Antiquities of Rajasthan*. According to him, Chauhans were Scythians who came to India from Central Asia. But then, Col. Tod's compulsions were completely different. Portraying all of Rajasthan's Kshatriya dynasties as foreign invaders was a narrative that suited the project of British colonialism.

But what of the 21st century battle over Prithviraj Chauhan? Responding to Jitesh Gujjar's claim that Prithviraj was a Gujjar because his father was called Gurjaradhipati, Virendra Singh Rathore, an IT professional from Rajasthan who has written *Prithviraj Chauhan: A Light on the Mist in History*, says: "Someshwar's maternal grandmother was in Patan, Gujarat. The word Gurjareshwar or Gurjaradhipati is used for Jaisingh Siddharaj, Someshwar's maternal grandfather."

"The word Gurjar," insists Mahavir Singh Sarwadi, convenor of the Kshatriya Yuvak Sangh, "was used for a particular place. Ravana was called Lankadhipati, but it does not mean his caste was Lanka. Southern Rajasthan and northern Gujarat were then called Gurjara Desh or Gurjarat, and Gurjaradhipati was the term for the king of that land. The castes that came out from these parts such as Gurjar Gaur Brahmins or Gurjar Pratihar Rajputs still use Gurjar with their name." Not letting nuance come in the way of his argument, Jitesh Gujjar maintains, "It was a tradition till medieval times to name places after the ruling dynasties. For example, Rajasthan was originally called Rajputana because it was ruled by the Rajputs. Accordingly, Gujarat was called Gujjar country because it was ruled by the Gujjars." And the Chauhans are said to have been Pratihara vassals who moved from Gujarat to Rajasthan who subsequently gained in territory and influence.

Meanwhile, there is little consensus regarding the origins of the Gujjars themselves. Colonial historian Vincent Arthur Smith in his *The Early History of India* ascribes a blood relation with the Huns. Others believe them to be the inhabitants of Georgia who blazed a trail across central Asia, Iraq, Iran, Afghanistan and the Khyber Pass to reach Gujarat circa the 5th and 6th centuries. Yet others believe them to be indigenous to the subcontinent. Some went on to claim a Brahmin lineage, others a Kshatriya or Rajput one through a process of Sanskritisation. There are Gujjars among India's Muslims, Sikhs, Christians and, perhaps Buddhists, too. In the present day, they are mostly concentrated in north India, in Jammu and Kashmir and in the states of Himachal Pradesh, Uttar Pradesh, Haryana, Madhya Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Delhi, Rajasthan, Gujarat and Maharashtra. They can be upper caste in one region, and OBC in another.

However, whether a Gujjar or Rajput raja, Prithviraj Chauhan remains an interesting character of Indian history and a prominent figure in the national iconography alongside such greats as Rana Pratap and Shivaji. *Samrat Prithviraj*, though, seems to have run into a spot of trouble at the box office. After a disappointing opening, on day 5, reports say, some shows of the film even had to be cancelled for lack of an audience. ■